

Baptismal Regeneration Denial

doc-baptismal-regeneration-denial

Sacraments · Baptism · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

breadth broad
directness direct
variants stable

Statement under examination

Baptism is the outward sign of an inward reality accomplished by grace through faith, and does not in itself effect regeneration or wash away sin apart from the inner work of the Spirit and faith.

In plain language

This proposition denies that baptism by itself produces the new birth or washes away sin, treating the water as a sign of an inward change worked by the Spirit and received through faith. Several passages pull toward that reading. Ephesians 2:8 uses a perfect tense (a completed action whose result still stands), 'you have been saved' (sesosmenoi), grounded in grace through faith and called the gift of God, not out of works, naming no rite as the cause. Romans 4:11 calls Abraham's circumcision a 'seal' (sphragis) of a righteousness he already had by faith while uncircumcised, the grammar of a sign placed on a prior reality. In Acts 10 the Spirit falls on the hearers while Peter is still speaking, before any water; Luke 23:43 promises paradise to a crucified man never baptized; and in 1 Corinthians 1:17 Paul says Christ sent him 'not to baptize but to preach' (ouk baptizein alla euangelizesthai). But a second set of texts binds the rite to salvation in the words themselves, and vocabulary cannot rank the two patterns. Acts 2:38 says be baptized 'for' (eis) the forgiveness of sins, where that little preposition can mean in order to obtain or with reference to. John 3:5 speaks of being born 'of water and Spirit' (ex hydatos kai pneumatous), where water has several defensible senses. Titus 3:5 joins 'washing' (loutron) and 'regeneration' (palingenesia) in one phrase, and both of those words appear only twice in the whole canon, so neither sense can be pinned down. Acts 22:16 couples being baptized with 'washing away' (apolouo) sins. Mark 16:16 pairs faith and baptism with being saved, yet condemns only unbelief, not the lack of baptism. 1 Peter 3:21 makes 'baptism' (baptisma) the subject of the verb 'saves' (sozei), then at once says it is not the removal of dirt from the body but the 'appeal or pledge' (eperotema) of a good conscience toward God through the resurrection. The single word that would settle the matter, eperotema, occurs nowhere else in the Bible (it is a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), so its exact sense cannot be checked against other uses. Because the deciding terms are rare or two-way and the canon supplies two patterns the words do not rank, skilled readers reach opposite conclusions, and the honest verdict here is disputed with low confidence rather than a clean affirmation.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0011	Ἀβραάμ	Abraam	Abraham	
G0191	ἀκούω	akouō	to hear	
G0203	ἀκροβυστία	akrobustia	uncircumcision	
G0499	ἀντίτυπος	antitypos	representation	2
G0595	ἀπόθεσις	apothesis	removal	2
G0628	ἀπολούω	apolouo	to wash off	2

G0859	ἄφεσις	aphesis	forgiveness	17
G0907	βαπτίζω	baptizo	to baptize	82
G0908	βάπτισμα	baptisma	baptism	23
G1343	δικαιοσύνη	dikaiosyne	righteousness	94
G1519	εἰς	eis	toward	1,824
G1537	ἐκ	ek	out from	
G1906	ἐπερώτημα	eperotema	pledge	1
G2983	λαμβάνω	lambanō	to take	
G3067	λουτρόν	loutron	washing	2
G3824	παλιγγενεσία	palingenesia	regeneration	2
G4061	περιτομή	peritome	circumcision	38
G4982	σώζω	sozo	to save	113
G4983	σῶμα	sōma	body	
G5204	ὕδωρ	hydor	water	80

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Two patterns sit in the same vocabulary and the words do not rank them. The denial is supported where salvation language appears with no rite: Ephesians 2:8 grounds the perfect-tense (a completed action whose result still stands) 'you have been saved' (sesosmenoi) in grace through faith as God's gift, not works; Romans 4:11 calls circumcision a 'seal' (sphragis) of a righteousness already reckoned to Abraham while he was still uncircumcised, the grammar of a sign placed on a prior reality; Acts 10:44-48 has the Spirit fall before water; Luke 23:43 promises paradise to a man never baptized; and 1 Corinthians 1:17 has Paul sent 'not to baptize but to preach the gospel' (ouk baptizein alla euangelizesthai). But the rite is verbally bound to salvation in a second set: Acts 2:38 'let him be baptized for the forgiveness of sins' (baptistheto eis aphesisin hamartion), where the preposition 'into/for' (eis) is genuinely two-way, Titus 3:5 'through the washing of regeneration' (dia loutrou palingenesias) couples washing to regeneration, John 3:5 'from water' (ex hydatos) has several defensible referents, Acts 22:16 'be baptized and wash away your sins' (baptisai kai apolousai tas hamartias), Mark 16:16 'the one believing and being baptized will be saved' (pisteusas kai baptistheis sothesetai), and 1 Peter 3:21 makes 'baptism' (baptisma) the grammatical subject of the verb 'saves' (sozei). The decisive lexical fact is that the verse which would settle it, 1 Peter 3:21, qualifies 'saves' (sozei) with 'appeal or pledge' (eperotema), which is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) whose sense, appeal versus pledge, cannot be triangulated, so the words leave the case open.

Scripture

Eph.2.8 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4982 σώζω, G1343 δικαιοσύνη

Force. The perfect periphrastic (a two-word verb form expressing a completed action whose result still stands) 'you have been and remain saved' (este sesosmenoi) is grounded by 'by grace' (chariti, a dative of means, that is, a noun in the 'by means of X' grammatical form) and 'through faith' (dia pisteos), and the clause adds 'and this not from yourselves, the gift of God' (kai touto ouk ex hymon, theou to doron), with verse 9 'not out of works' (ouk ex ergon). The named saving instrument is grace appropriated by faith, with no rite supplied as the effective cause, which matches the stem's claim that the inward reality is accomplished by grace through faith.

Rom.4.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4061 περιτομή, G1343 δικαιοσύνη

Force. Abraham received the 'sign' (semeion) of circumcision as a 'seal' (sphragis) of the 'righteousness of faith' (dikaiosyne tes pisteos) he held while still 'in uncircumcision' (en akrobystia). The temporal order is decisive: the righteousness is reckoned first by faith, and the bodily rite is appended as a seal of an already existing standing. This is the grammar of an outward sign placed on a prior inward reality, which the stem applies to baptism by analogy.

Acts.10.44 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0191 ἀκούω

Force. 'While Peter was still speaking' (eti lalountos tou Petrou), the Holy Spirit 'fell' (epepesen) on all those hearing the word. The aorist (a completed past action) with the temporal genitive-absolute participle (a 'while X was happening' grammatical construction) places Spirit reception during the proclamation and before any water, establishing that the inward bestowal preceded the rite.

Acts.10.47 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G2983 λαμβάνω

Force. Peter asks whether anyone can withhold the water to baptize 'those who received the Holy Spirit' (hoitines to pneuma to hagian elabon) 'as we also did' (hos kai hemeis). The aorist (a completed past action) 'received' (elabon) is antecedent to the proposed 'to be baptized' (baptisthenai, aorist infinitive, a completed-action 'to do X' verb form). The water ratifies a reception already granted, not effects it, supporting the sign reading.

Luke.23.43 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4982 σῶζω

Force. 'Today you will be with me in paradise' (semeron met emou ese en to paradeiso) is spoken to a crucified man who can receive no baptism. The promise of immediate paradise rests on his appeal to Christ alone, showing salvation conferred apart from the rite in at least this case. 'I save' (sozo) is not the verb here, but the saving outcome, paradise with Christ, is the lexical equivalent, conferred without water.

1Cor.1.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω

Force. 'For Christ did not send me to baptize but to preach the gospel' (ou gar apesteilen me Christos baptizein alla euangelizesthai). The 'not...but' (ou...alla) construction sets baptizing in explicit contrast to gospel proclamation and subordinates the rite to it. If baptism itself effected salvation, ranking preaching above it would be lexically strange, so the contrast favors the sign reading. This text was not in the bundle anchors and was added on direct concordance traversal of 'I baptize' (baptizo, G0907).

1Pet.3.21 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0908 βάπτισμα, G4982 σῶζω, G1906 ἐπερώτημα, G0499 ἀντίτυπος, G0595 ἀπόθεσις

Force. 'Which also, an antitype (a corresponding fulfillment of an earlier pattern), now saves you, baptism' (ho kai hymas antitypon nyn sozei baptisma). The verb 'saves' (sozei) takes 'baptism' (baptisma) as its grammatical subject, which on its face couples baptism to salvation, and 'baptism' (baptisma) and 'I save' (sozo) co-occur in only this one verse in the entire canon. But the same verse qualifies it: 'not removal of dirt of the flesh' (ou sarkos apothesis rypou), 'but the appeal or pledge of a good conscience toward God' (alla syneideseos agathes eperotema eis theon), 'through the resurrection of Jesus Christ' (dia anastaseos Iesou Christou). The author internally relocates the saving force from the external washing to the conscience pledge grounded in the resurrection. 'Appeal or pledge' (eperotema, G1906) is a canonical hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), occurring only here, so its sense (appeal, question, or pledge) cannot be triangulated from biblical usage, which is the exact reason the verse both raises and refuses to settle the complication.

Acts.2.38 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G1519 εις, G0859 ἄφεσις

Force. 'Let each of you be baptized for the forgiveness of your sins' (baptistheto hekastos hymon eis aphenin ton hamartion hymon), where 'be baptized' (baptistheto) takes the preposition 'into/for' (eis) governing 'forgiveness' (aphesin). The preposition 'into/for' (eis) can be telic (in order to obtain) or, by some lexical analyses, causal or based-upon (with reference to a forgiveness granted on repentance), and the plural 'repent' (metanoesate) governs the singular 'let him be baptized' (baptistheto), foregrounding repentance. The bare prepositional phrase does not by itself settle whether forgiveness is effected by or merely signified at the rite, so the verse is lexically indeterminate.

Acts.22.16 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G0628 ἀπολούω

Force. 'Rise, be baptized and wash away your sins, calling on his name' (anastas baptisai kai apolousai tas hamartias sou epikalesamenos to onoma autou). 'Be baptized' (baptisai) and 'wash away' (apolousai, G0628) are coupled, which on its face binds the rite to cleansing. But 'I wash away' (apolouo) occurs only twice in the canon, and its other use, 1 Corinthians 6:11 'you were washed... in the name... and by the Spirit' (apelousasthe...en to onomati...kai en to pneumati), attributes the same washing to the Spirit, and the final participle 'calling on the name' (epikalesamenos) names the appeal that accompanies it. The two-occurrence lexeme (vocabulary item) will not by itself fix the rite as the cause rather than the occasion.

Mark.16.16 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G4982 σώζω

Force. 'The one believing and being baptized will be saved' (ho pisteusas kai baptistheis sothesetai), 'but the one disbelieving will be condemned' (ho de apistesas katakritheisetai). The first clause pairs faith and baptism with 'I save' (sozo) (this is the only verse where 'I baptize' (baptizo) and 'I save' (sozo) co-occur), but the second clause makes only disbelief, not the absence of baptism, the ground of condemnation. The asymmetry, faith plus baptism in the positive but only unbelief in the negative, leaves the rite's necessity grammatically open rather than asserted.

John.3.5 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G5204 ὕδωρ, G1519 εις

Force. 'Unless one is born from water and Spirit' (ean me tis gennethe ex hydatos kai pneumatos), 'he cannot enter into the kingdom of God' (ou dynatai eiselthein eis ten basileian tou theou). The genitive (a noun in the 'of-X / from-X' grammatical form) 'from water' (ex hydatos) has multiple defensible referents in the lexical and contextual data: a hendiadys (one idea expressed by two coupled nouns, water-and-Spirit as one cleansing-rebirth), an allusion to natural birth set against spiritual birth, or a washing rite. The single preposition 'from/out of' (ek) governing both 'water' (hydatos) and 'Spirit' (kai pneumatos) is itself read as one event or as two. Morphology (the study of word forms) and lexicon (the dictionary stock of words) alone cannot adjudicate the referent, so this text does not lexically confirm or deny baptismal efficacy.

Titus.3.5 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3067 λουτρόν, G3824 παλιγγενεσία, G4982 σώζω

Force. 'He saved us through the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit' (esosen hemas dia loutrou palingenesias kai anakainoseos pneumatos hagiou). 'Washing' or 'laver' (loutron) is coupled to 'regeneration' (palingenesia) by the genitive (a noun in the 'of-X' grammatical form), and 'through' (dia) marks it as the channel. Both 'washing' (loutron) and 'regeneration' (palingenesia) occur only twice in the canon, so neither sense is canon-stable: 'washing' (loutron) can denote the literal water rite or, as in Ephesians 5:26 'with the washing of water by the word' (loutro tou hydatos en rhemati), a cleansing tied to the word, and 'regeneration' (palingenesia) in Matthew 19:28 means cosmic renewal, not personal rebirth. The immediately preceding 'not from works' (ouk ex ergon) pulls against a mechanical reading. This is the strongest verbal link between washing and regeneration in the corpus and is not dissolvable on lexicon alone.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.4.11	Gen.17.10	tsk	1
Rom.4.11	Rom.2.28	tsk	1
Rom.4.10	Gen.15.5	tsk	1
Acts.10.47	Acts.8.12	tsk	1
1Pet.3.21	Ezek.36.25	tsk	1
Titus.3.5	Ps.51.10	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Acts.2.38 · addressed

The crux is the preposition 'into/for' (eis) in 'let him be baptized for the forgiveness of sins' (baptistheto eis aphesin hamartion). The preposition 'into/for' (eis) with this verb can express purpose (in order to receive forgiveness) or, on some lexical readings, the basis or occasion (with reference to a forgiveness granted on repentance). The plural imperative 'repent' (metanoesate) governs the singular 'let him be baptized' (baptistheto), foregrounding repentance. Lexicon (the dictionary stock of words) and morphology (the study of word forms) permit both a sacramental-effect reading (baptism actually causes forgiveness) and a sign reading (baptism marks a forgiveness already granted), so the verse does not by itself overturn the proposition but also does not confirm it. Marked complicates and addressed without forcing a one-sided lexical verdict.

John.3.5 · addressed

'From water and Spirit' (ex hydatos kai pneumatos) carries at least three defensible lexical referents (a hendiadys (one idea expressed by two coupled nouns) for one Spirit-cleansing rebirth, natural birth contrasted with Spirit birth, or a washing rite), and the single preposition 'from/out of' (ek) governing both nouns is itself read as one event and as two. Because the referent of 'water' (hydatos) cannot be fixed by lexicon alone, the verse neither establishes nor refutes baptismal efficacy on lexical grounds; it remains a genuine complication.

Titus.3.5 · addressed

'Washing of regeneration' (loutrou palingenesias) couples washing and regeneration via the genitive (a noun in the 'of-X' grammatical form), with 'through' (dia) marking instrument, the most direct verbal link to a regenerating washing in the corpus. Yet both 'washing' (loutron, G3067) and 'regeneration' (palingenesia, G3824) occur only twice in the canon, so their senses cannot be triangulated: 'washing' (loutron) at Ephesians 5:26 attaches to the word ('by the word', en rhemati), and 'regeneration' (palingenesia) at Matthew 19:28 names cosmic renewal, not personal rebirth. The same sentence opens with 'not from works' (ouk ex ergon) of righteousness we did. The lexical data sustains both a sacramental (the rite itself accomplishes it) and a metaphorical (the washing pictures it) reading, so the coupling is acknowledged as a real tension the words do not resolve.

1Pet.3.21 · addressed

'Baptism' (baptisma) is the explicit subject of 'saves' (sozei), the sharpest grammatical assertion of baptismal salvation in the corpus, and 'baptism' (baptisma) and 'I save' (sozo) co-occur in only this one verse. The verse supplies its own qualifier: 'not removal of fleshly dirt' (ou sarkos apothesis rypou), 'but the appeal or pledge of a good conscience toward God' (alla syneideseos agathes eperotema eis theon), relocating the saving ground from the external washing to the conscience pledge anchored 'through the resurrection of Jesus Christ' (dia anastaseos Iesou Christou). Because 'appeal or pledge' (eperotema, G1906) is a canonical hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), its sense (appeal versus pledge) cannot be settled from biblical usage, so the verse both states baptism saves and qualifies the manner, leaving competent readers divided. Addressed but not dissolved.

Acts.22.16 · addressed

'Be baptized and wash away your sins' (baptisai kai apolousai tas hamartias) couples baptism with washing away sins, but 'I wash away' (apolouo, G0628) occurs only twice in the canon, and its other use at 1 Corinthians 6:11 ascribes the same washing to the name of the Lord and the Spirit ('in the name...and by the Spirit', en to onomati...kai en to pneumati). The accompanying participle 'calling on the name' (epikalesamenos) names a coordinate appeal. A two-occurrence lexeme (vocabulary item) split between a rite context and a Spirit context cannot fix the rite as the effecting cause, so the text complicates without being resolved either way.

Mark.16.16 · addressed

'The one believing and being baptized will be saved' (pisteusas kai baptistheis sothesetai) pairs faith and baptism with 'I save' (sozo), but the parallel negative clause condemns only 'the one disbelieving' (ho apistesas), not the unbaptized. The asymmetry, faith plus baptism in the positive clause but unbelief alone in the negative, means the grammar does not assert the rite as necessary to salvation; it could mark baptism as the normal accompaniment of the faith that saves. The clause is genuinely open on its own wording, so it complicates rather than settles.

Concordance traversed

G4982, G0907, G0908, G1519, G0859, G1906, G0499, G0595, G0628, G3067, G3824, G5204, G4061, G1343, G0203, G0011, G1537, G4983

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

The cited New Testament verses lie outside the open-cbgm 3 John sample (not_in_ecm_scope is true in the bundle), so CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a technique for tracing manuscript family relationships) was not run. SBLGNT (Society of Biblical Literature Greek New Testament) apparatus diamonds visible in the bundle (Ephesians 2:8 'through' (dia), Acts 10:45 'holy' (hagiu), 1 Peter 3:21 'and...now' (kai...nyn), Luke 23:43 'I say to you' (soi...lego), Mark 16:16 lies in the disputed longer ending) touch wording but not the lemmas (dictionary headwords) that bear the verdict: 'I save' (sozo), 'I baptize' (baptizo), 'baptism' (baptisma), 'into/for' (eis), 'appeal or pledge' (eperotema), 'washing' (loutron), 'regeneration' (palingenesia), 'I wash away' (apolouo). Even granting the textual instability of Mark 16:9-20, the verdict does not rest on Mark 16:16 alone, so no examined variant changes the disputed reading.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, sacramental_realism, memorialism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

sign_and_seal (Rom 4 analogy): affirms · Reading baptism through the circumcision 'seal' (sphragis) pattern of Romans 4:11, where the rite seals a righteousness already reckoned by faith while uncircumcised, yields the proposition: the outward act signifies and ratifies a prior inward grace and does not itself effect it. Ephesians 2:8 grace through faith, Acts 10 Spirit before water, Luke 23:43 paradise without water, and 1 Corinthians 1:17 preaching ranked above baptizing all reinforce this reading.

sacramental_realism (instrumental cause): denies · Reading Acts 2:38 'for the forgiveness' (eis aphesis) telically (as expressing purpose), Titus 3:5 'through the washing of regeneration' (dia loutrou palingenesias) as the regenerating bath through which God saves, John 3:5 'from water' (ex hydatos) as the rite, Acts 22:16 'be baptized and wash away' (baptisai kai apolousai) as washing sins away in the act, Mark 16:16 'being baptized will be saved' (baptistheis sothesetai), and 1 Peter 3:21 'baptism saves' (baptisma sozei) at face value yields baptism as the divinely appointed instrument through which forgiveness and regeneration are conveyed, contradicting the proposition. On this lens the saving-language verbs and prepositions are taken in their plain instrumental force.

narrative_order (Acts 10 and Luke 23): affirms · The Cornelius sequence, Spirit 'falling' (epepesen) before water with 'they received' (elabon) antecedent to the proposed 'to be baptized' (baptisthenai), and the unbaptized criminal granted paradise, show salvation and Spirit reception conferred prior to or apart from the rite in the narrative data, favoring the sign reading on the order of events the verbs encode.

The verdict turns on contested prepositions and underdetermined lexemes (vocabulary items): 'into/for' (eis) in Acts 2:38, 'from/out of' (ek) in John 3:5, the coupling of 'washing' (loutron) and 'regeneration' (palingenesia) in Titus 3:5, the subject relation of 'baptism' (baptisma) to 'saves' (sozei) in 1 Peter 3:21, and 'I wash away' (apolouo) in Acts 22:16. The analogy of Scripture pulls in opposite directions depending on which texts are treated as controlling, which is why the lexical pattern is contested rather than settled. The narrative-order and sign-and-seal lenses are reported in their strongest form, not as the default; the sacramental-realism lens is given its plain-sense reading symmetrically, since the words genuinely sustain it.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does the New Testament lexical and grammatical data indicate that water baptism itself effects regeneration and the washing away of sin, or that it signifies a regeneration accomplished by the Spirit and received by faith, or is the data indeterminate between these?

The original stem is preloaded against baptismal regeneration. It builds in the conclusion through the phrases 'outward sign of an inward reality' and 'does not in itself effect regeneration', which is the very point at issue and presupposes a sign or memorial reading over a sacramental-instrumental one. The verdict was derived on the original stem, but the neutralized form states the question without prejudging which lexical reading prevails. No web fallback was used; the lexical store was queried directly and supplied sufficient anchor lemmas (dictionary headwords), canon counts, and collocations (words that habitually occur together).

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Pet.3.21
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.2.38
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Titus.3.5
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1906
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1519
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0628
lexicon	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	G4982
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Pet.3.21

License audit

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Reason. MACULA-Greek is CC-BY-NC-4.0 (non-commercial, redistribute=false), used for the sozo (G4982) glossing. Because at least one source is non-redistributable, the aggregate evidence is not safe to publish in bulk.

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Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · cross-tradition-divergent